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Parties' issue responsiveness between elections

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ABSTRACT

Are parties responsive to short-term changes in election polls? While party responsiveness to election outcomes has been widely studied, less is known about how parties adjust issue attention between elections. This study addresses this question using the comprehensive PARTYPRESS database. Supervised machine learning methods are employed to construct a dynamic measure of parties' issue attention based on over 250,000 press releases from 68 parties across nine countries between 2010 and 2020. The results provide little evidence that declining poll support prompts parties to shift their issue priorities. Parties do not consistently emphasise their owned issues, pay greater attention to popular issues, or adjust their issue focus to align with successful competitors. These findings have important implications for understanding party responsiveness and the dynamics of electoral competition.

KEYWORDS Issue agendas; political parties; party competition; responsiveness; party communication

Are parties responsive to short-term changes in election polls? Polls provide parties with real-time feedback on public opinion, highlighting which issues resonate most strongly with voters. By adapting their issue agenda, parties can demonstrate responsiveness to the concerns and priorities of the electorate, increasing their chances of garnering support. In addition, parties can use polls to identify emerging issues or changing public sentiment, allowing them to stay ahead of the curve and address pressing concerns. Adapting their issue agenda based on polling data seems like a natural move that should help parties to effectively shape their campaign messaging. However, while party responsiveness to election results has received much attention (e.g. Adams *et al.* 2004; Somer-Topcu 2009; Spoon and Klüver 2014), we know little about how parties adjust their political messages to public opinion polls. This article addresses this

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question by studying whether parties adjust their issue agendas in response to public opinion polls.

Previous research has investigated whether political parties are responsive to voters with regard to the policy issues political parties emphasise in their election manifestos (Klüver and Spoon 2016; Pennings 2005; Spoon and Klüver 2014; Wagner and Meyer 2014). These studies have shown that political parties listen to the policy priorities of voters, but that the issue responsiveness varies considerably across parties and elections. The extent to which parties respond to the issue priorities of citizens is conditioned by the electoral context (Spoon and Klüver 2014), by party type (Klüver and Spoon 2016), by the polarisation of the issue (Spoon and Klüver 2015) and by organisational structures of political parties (Wagner and Meyer 2014). While much of this literature builds expectations from manifestos, our data are press releases that capture day-to-day, reactive communication; dynamics may therefore differ from long-horizon programmatic documents, and we explicitly leverage this high-frequency lens throughout the article.

There are, however, only a few studies that investigate whether political parties respond to public opinion polls. Pereira (2019) studies party behaviour during election campaigns and shows that party leaders respond to public opinion polls during this time period. More specifically, party leaders use polling information strategically as mobilisation tools. They are more likely to emphasise their own policy positions and the policy positions of other parties after disappointing polls, and they use less negative campaigning when the polls look good for them. Pereira (2020), moreover, studies whether parties adjust their campaign messages during election campaigns in response to public opinion polls. He shows that parties that perform well in the polls maintain their policy positions, but that they change their policy positions in response to a decline in the polls. Ivanusch *et al.* (2023) study parties' responsiveness at the German federal election campaign 2021. They find that parties respond to competitors and external events but not to public salience. Importantly, they detect no differences in parties' behaviour depending on their standing in the polls.

While these studies have considerably advanced our understanding of the short-term dynamics of party competition, they are limited to studying election campaigns. Election campaigns are short and extraordinary times that are crucially different from the rest of the electoral cycle. First, during an election campaign, there is a concentrated and heightened focus on political candidates and parties. Media coverage, public attention, and political discourse revolve around the campaign, leading to a significant increase in political activity. Second, election campaigns are primarily aimed at mobilising voters while the legislative process

largely stands still. Political parties engage in various activities such as public rallies, speeches, debates, advertisements, and door-to-door canvassing to garner support and persuade voters to cast their ballots in their favour. Third, election campaigns often involve a more focused and refined political messaging strategy. Political parties aim to communicate their policy profile in a concise and persuasive manner to differentiate themselves from their opponents. Finally, the competitive nature of election campaigns sets them apart from the rest of the electoral cycle. Parties intensify their efforts to gain an advantage over their opponents. They may engage in negative campaigning, highlighting their opponents' weaknesses or mistakes, in an attempt to sway public opinion in their favour.

Thus, election campaigns are fundamentally different from the rest of the electoral cycle. Consequently, previous research has already pointed to the importance of cyclical effects of politics (Lupia and Strom 1995; Sagarzazu and Klüver 2017), but until now, there has been no study that examines the effect of public opinion polls on party competition during the entire electoral cycle. In this study, our aim is to overcome this important gap by studying parties' responsiveness to polls throughout the entire legislative term.

Empirically, we use supervised machine learning methods to build a dynamic measure of parties' issue attention, based on the new comprehensive PARTYPRESS Dataset covering more than 250,000 press releases from 68 parties across nine countries from 2010 until 2019 (Erfort *et al.* 2023). Press releases have the advantage that they are published daily, that parties can freely choose what to discuss, and that the media regularly report about them (Meyer *et al.* 2020; Sagarzazu and Klüver 2017; Schaffner 2006). We are therefore able to study the responsiveness of parties to public opinion polls across the entire electoral cycle.

We combine the data on parties' issue attention with polling data to evaluate three hypotheses about parties' responses to changes in the polls. As we discuss in the following, previous work proposes three perspectives on the issues parties should turn to when they notice a considerable decline in support in the polls. They could focus on the issues they own, that are publicly salient, or try to adapt to issues of successful competitors. Evaluating the different hypotheses using dynamic panel models, we find little support that strong changes in polls lead to issue attention changes in predictable ways. Our results find some support only for niche parties, which tend to focus on their strength issues when they lose in the polls. But for other parties, we do not find evidence in this direction – neither during the election campaigns nor outside of them. These findings still have important implications for our understanding of party responsiveness and the dynamics of electoral competition.

Theoretical expectations

While party responsiveness to election results has received much attention, we know little about the dynamics of issue competition during the legislative term. We argue that polls provide parties with valuable information about voter preferences, concerns, and attitudes, which can help them tailor their issue agenda. When political parties receive polling data, they analyse it to understand the current political landscape, identify trends, and evaluate their own standing relative to their opponents. Several scholars have accordingly shown that politicians systematically take polls on public opinion into account when making policy decisions (Hager and Hilbig 2020; Jacobs and Shapiro 1995; Pickup and Hobolt 2015). Most notably, Hager and Hilbig (2020) show that the German government launches on average 150 public opinion surveys per year and that politicians change the topics they address and also their policy positions in response to exposure to public opinion polls. We posit that a decline in the polls sends a signal to political parties that their current strategy is not effective. We argue that political parties carefully analyse the public opinion data and the strategies of their competitors and adjust their issue agenda to maximise electoral support.

The question is how political parties adjust their issue agenda when they face a decline in the polls. There are three lines of reasoning which arrive at competing predictions: First, building on the issue ownership theory, political parties should focus on policy issues on which they are considered to be particularly competent (Petrocik 1996). Second, the riding the wave theory instead posits that political parties should highlight political issues that are salient among voters to signal responsiveness (Ansolabehere and Iyengar 1994). A third argument that we derive from sociological institutionalism and prior literature on diffusion is that political parties should copy the issue strategies of successful competitors (Böhmelt *et al.* 2016; DiMaggio and Powell 1983).

Regarding how parties read polling signals, recent evidence shows that aggregate poll shocks can translate into issue-specific adjustments via the mediated agenda: in Denmark, MPs increased alignment with contemporaneous top media issues after negative polls in a pre/post design around monthly polls (Pedersen and Seeberg 2025). Building on this logic, we evaluate whether parties (not individual MPs) adjust their centralised press-release agendas across nine countries when polls turn negative, using harmonised monthly measures of attention and salience.

Issue ownership

The issue ownership theory posits that political parties can effectively 'own' policy issues (Budge and Farlie 1983; Petrocik 1996). According to

this theory, parties strategically focus on selected policy issues in order to establish themselves as the most competent and credible actors on those issues, thereby attracting voter support.

Political parties seek to develop a reputation for expertise and effectiveness in specific policy domains. By consistently emphasising and advocating for certain issues, parties aim to convince voters that they are the most capable of addressing the challenges and concerns associated with those particular policy areas (Petrocik 1996). This strategy helps parties differentiate themselves from their opponents and strengthens their appeal to voters who prioritise those issues. Issue ownership can be a long-term strategy for parties to build a loyal and consistent voter base. By associating themselves with specific policy issues over time, parties can cultivate a perception of consistency and commitment to those issues. This can lead to increased trust and support from voters who identify strongly with those policy concerns, resulting in a more stable and reliable support base for the party.

When political parties lose in the polls, it follows from issue ownership theory that parties would attempt to mobilise voters by emphasising policy issues on which they enjoy a reputation for competence. Voters make their vote choices by evaluating the competence of political parties to handle certain policy issues. Issue ownership theory argues that voters identify the party that is the most competent problem-solver on an issue and cast the ballot for that party. When a party consistently highlights its ownership of specific policy areas, it signals to voters that they are knowledgeable and competent in addressing those concerns. This perception of expertise and effectiveness can instill trust in voters, who may feel more confident in supporting a party that they believe can effectively tackle the issues that matter to them. However, it is moreover not sufficient that political parties are perceived as competent problem-solvers on an issue; the issue also needs to be salient to voters (Bélanger and Meguid 2008).

Since voters support political parties on the basis of their competence to deal with issues that are important to the voters, political parties attempt to increase the salience of issues which they own in the minds of citizens. Political parties see no electoral gains from spending time and resources on issues owned by adversaries (Petrocik 1996). Parties therefore attempt to steer public attention towards their owned issues by emphasising policy issues on which they are perceived to be competent, while downplaying issues on which opponents enjoy an advantage. By emphasising their own issues, political parties seek to increase the salience of beneficial issues among the electorate so that party evaluations on their owned issues shape voter decisions at the ballot box. As a result, political parties tend to talk about issues that they own to reap electoral gains (Budge and Farlie 1983; Petrocik 1996; Riker 1996). Based on issue

ownership theory, one would accordingly expect that political parties emphasise the policy issues that they own when they have lost in the polls.

Hypothesis 1: Political parties pay more attention to political issues that they own than to other political issues when they face a decline in the polls.

Riding the wave

The ‘riding the wave’ theory suggests that political parties often respond to the issue priorities of voters in order to gain electoral support (Ansolabehere and Iyengar 1994). According to this theory, political parties closely monitor public opinion and identify the key concerns and priorities of the electorate. They then strategically position themselves by advocating for policies and solutions that align with those concerns, effectively ‘riding the wave’ of popular sentiment. Instead of conceiving issue competition as a top-down process in which voters take cues from political parties as proposed by the issue ownership theory, the riding the wave theory conceptualises issue emphasis as a bottom-up process in which political parties respond to the issue priorities of voters.

In practice, this theory implies that political parties are highly responsive to the changing dynamics of public opinion (Ansolabehere and Iyengar 1994; Fournier *et al.* 2003; Sides 2006). They constantly adapt their platforms and policy positions to address the most salient issues at any given time. For example, if voters express increasing concern about economic inequality, parties may incorporate policies aimed at wealth redistribution or job creation into their platforms. Similarly, if there is a growing public demand for environmental sustainability, parties may emphasise their commitment to renewable energy and conservation. By riding the wave of public opinion, parties aim to capture the support and loyalty of voters who prioritise specific issues, ultimately enhancing their chances of electoral success. By ‘riding the wave’ on publicly salient issues, political parties signal responsiveness to their voters. They can enhance their popularity by demonstrating to their voters that they listen to them and that they take their concerns seriously.

Sides (2007: 467) argues that political parties would be considered ‘out of touch’ if they did not talk about the issues that are salient in the minds of citizens. Ansolabehere and Iyengar (1994: 337) similarly argues that ‘by advertising on the major issues of the day, candidates are more likely to be seen as concerned, responsive and informed’. Finally, Damore (2004) even explicitly argues political parties should also talk about policy issues even when these are owned by their competitors. A number of recent studies have accordingly shown that political parties are responsive to the issue

priorities of voters in election manifestos (Klüver and Spoon 2016; Spoon and Klüver 2014; Wagner and Meyer 2014), in the press releases that they draft (Klüver and Sagarzazu 2016) and that politicians who lose in the polls communicate more on issues that are on the media agenda in a pre/post design around monthly polls (Pedersen and Seeberg 2025). Importantly, while polls are noisy and aggregated, they are precisely the high-frequency signals parties typically rely on between elections, whereas election results provide lower-frequency, high-salience signals that also guide strategy.

Relatedly, Pedersen and Seeberg (2025) show for Danish MPs on Facebook that negative poll shocks raise alignment with contemporaneous top media issues. Our design differs along three dimensions that matter for responsiveness: (i) we study parties (not individual MPs) and their centralised press releases across nine countries; (ii) we operationalise public salience via harmonised search data rather than country-specific media codings; and (iii) we evaluate month-to-month within-party adjustments outside campaigns across a decade. These scope differences help reconcile why we find limited mid-cycle responsiveness at the party level even as MP-level media alignment increases after negative polls in a single-country setting.

Hypothesis 2: The attention that political parties pay to policy issues increases with the salience of these issues to voters when they face a decline in the polls.

Sociological institutionalism

A third explanation that we put forward in this article is based on sociological institutionalism (DiMaggio and Powell 1983). Sociological institutionalism starts with the observation that organisations of the same kind typically develop very similar structures and practices. The theory explains the organisational similarity with three mechanisms, namely coercive isomorphism, normative isomorphism and mimetic isomorphism. Coercive isomorphism arises from formal regulations, laws, and governmental policies that organisations must comply with to avoid penalties or loss of legitimacy. Normative isomorphism emerges from social expectations, cultural values, and professional standards that shape what is considered appropriate behaviour within a particular industry or sector. Finally, mimetic isomorphism occurs when organisations imitate successful models or practices in situations of uncertainty, assuming that what works for others will work for them as well.

We argue that mimetic isomorphism equally applies to political parties, which have to make strategic decisions about how to position themselves in the electoral arena in a situation of uncertainty (see also Böhmelt *et al.*

2016). Following the logic of mimetic isomorphism, we argue that political parties resort to copying the issue emphasis strategies of successful parties as a strategic response when they experience a decline in the polls. Political parties typically seek similar goals, namely votes (Downs 1957), offices (Riker 1962) or policies (De Swaan 1973). Parties face uncertainty in elections as they cannot be sure what the optimal strategy is to successfully compete in elections in order to reach their vote, office or policy objectives. Building on sociological institutionalism, we argue that political parties search for successful examples. They imitate the issue emphasis strategies of political parties that perform successfully in the polls. Parties observe that the successful party's issue emphasis has resonated with voters and garnered public support. By emphasising the same issues, the declining party hopes to tap into the popular sentiment and regain lost support.

Accordingly, a number of recent studies have shown that political parties imitate the behaviour of other parties. Government parties respond to the uncertainties of programmatic choice by imitating recently successful governing parties abroad (Böhmelt *et al.* 2016, 2017; Ezrow *et al.* 2021) or learning from their partners in transnational party alliances (Senninger *et al.* 2022), while at the same time distancing themselves from populist parties in government abroad (Adams *et al.* 2022). In addition, prior research has shown that political parties respond to position changes of other political parties in their own country (Adams and Somer-Topcu 2009; Gessler and Hunger 2022; Laver 2005; Williams 2015; Williams and Whitten 2015). Parties are responsive to voter transitions and adapt positions of parties that they lost voters to Abou-Chadi and Stoetzer (2020).

Thus, when facing electoral losses in the polls, we argue that political parties rely on parties that successfully perform in the polls as an example from which they can learn. In a situation of uncertainty in which they have to decide about the optimal issue attention strategy, they imitate successful competitors in the hope that such a strategy will be equally beneficial for them.

Hypothesis 3: Parties emphasise the issues of successful competitors when they face a decline in the polls.

Polls as information signals

Polls provide parties with continuous feedback about their electoral standing, but not all signals are equally meaningful. This aligns with the idea of punctuated responses (Baumgartner *et al.* 2009; Walgrave and Nuytemans 2009). We argue that parties are more likely to react when

they experience a large shock in the polls, that is, a substantial and noticeable decline in voter support. Minor fluctuations are part of normal polling volatility and are unlikely to trigger strategic adjustments, as parties may attribute them to measurement noise or temporary events. By contrast, a sizable drop in polling support sends a clear signal that the current strategy is not working, prompting parties to reconsider their issue agenda. Large shocks increase internal and external pressure to respond, heighten media attention, and strengthen the perception that change is necessary. Consequently, issue adaptation should be most likely when parties experience significant losses in their polling performance.

Hypothesis 4: A change in issue emphasis is more likely if a decline in the polls is large and persistent.

The role of the electoral cycle

The extent to which parties respond to polling shocks also depends on their position in the electoral cycle (Seeberg 2023). Early in the legislative term, parties are bound by coalition agreements and focus on governing, which makes even large polling shocks less consequential unless they persist over time. In the midterm period, opposition and niche parties are more likely to adjust their issue agendas, facing fewer organisational constraints and stronger incentives to react. Towards the end of the cycle, as elections approach, parties engage in ‘brand sharpening’ and are expected to reemphasize owned issues while reducing imitation (Sagarzazu and Klüver 2017). Responsiveness is therefore more likely towards the end of the term, when electoral incentives intensify, public attention increases, and parties seek to differentiate themselves from competitors. This cyclical logic helps explain why responsiveness is often limited outside campaign periods: when polling signals are weak or volatile, when losses cannot be clearly attributed to issue misalignment, or when coalition governance constrains flexibility, parties are unlikely to adjust their issue attention.

Hypothesis 5: A change in issue emphasis is more likely towards the end of the electoral cycle.

Data and methods

For readability, descriptive plots are presented in the [Online Appendix](#) and referenced inline where relevant (e.g., [Online Appendix Figure E.17](#) and [Online Appendix Figure E.18](#)).

Measurement of main variables

In this article, we draw on data from four main sources. First, we use press releases to measure the attention a party pays to an issue. Second, polling data gives us a dynamic measure of parties' polling performance. Third, we use survey data to determine issue ownership. And fourth, we take search data from Google to measure public salience.

Measuring issue attention through party press releases

We use press releases as a source to obtain estimates of parties' evolving issue agendas. Press releases bring together a range of benefits to measure parties' evolving issue agendas. First, they allow for a fine-grained depiction of parties' decisions to focus on particular issues in their centralised communication efforts. They are further unconstrained, as parties can choose freely what issues to address.

Party press releases from the PARTYPRESS database allow us to test our hypotheses for parties in nine European countries (Austria, Denmark, Germany, Ireland, the Netherlands, Poland, Spain, Sweden, and the UK) from 2010 onwards (Erfort *et al.* 2023). The database provides an issue coding into 21 unique topic areas building on the Comparative Agendas Project (Bonafont *et al.* 2020) for all the press releases.

In order to arrive at a monthly measure of the attention each party devotes to each issue, we divide the number of issue-specific press releases by the total number of press releases for each party and month. We further discuss and illustrate our measure for parties' issue attention in [Online Appendix C](#). [Online Appendix Figure E.19](#) shows coverage by party and year across countries; coverage is broad, with gaps primarily where survey-based issue-ownership data are unavailable.

Measuring electoral performance by aggregating polling data

We measure the electoral performance of parties using polling data obtained from Politico's Poll of Polls (POLITICO 2022). When there are multiple polling results for a given month, we take the arithmetic mean. Between elections, polling data provides the principal high-frequency signal on parties' electoral standing; by contrast, election results provide lower-frequency, high-salience signals that also inform strategic choices. For cross-national harmonisation with party press releases and public-salience measures, we aggregate at the monthly cadence used by most poll-of-polls indices. See [Online Appendix Figure E.17](#) for the distribution of monthly polling changes across parties.

Measuring issue ownership using competence scores in surveys

For each issue, we define the party most preferred by survey respondents as the issue owner. We draw on the Issue Ownership Dataset by Seeberg

(2017) based on national election studies. The dataset provides information about the issue owners in seven of the nine countries, and 19 of the 21 issue categories in the PARTYPRESS Database. The issue areas in the ownership dataset also use the coding scheme from the Comparative Agendas Project (Bonafont *et al.* 2020). We use the most recent measure for each country, assuming stable issue ownership throughout our analysis period.

Measuring public salience through search data

We compile an extensive dataset of Google Trends search data to construct a public salience measure for all issues and countries with monthly data points for our entire sample period. While media-based salience can capture the mediated agenda (see Pedersen and Seeberg 2025), assembling a harmonised media indicator across nine countries and 21 issues is beyond scope. Google Trends data has been used to predict a range of economic parameters such as the unemployment rate by measuring the frequency of search queries for jobs (Siliverstovs and Wochner 2018). Google Trends data has also been found to work well to estimate issue salience among the public, although the salience of some issues is difficult to capture (Mellon 2013). Therefore, we restrict some analyses to specific issues in the section on ‘Additional Analyses’. In political science applications, Google Trends data has been used successfully as a measure for the public salience of immigration (Gessler and Hunger 2022). We validate our measure against survey data in [Online Appendix D.1](#).

We extract relevant keywords for each issue and country from the press releases in each country. More specifically, we build Naive Bayes supervised text models. First, we take the 20 keywords with the largest model weights per party. Second, we only keep search terms that are in the top 20 of at least two parties to avoid overly party-specific search terms. Third, after the collection of the search trends, we exclude search terms with an arithmetic mean above the 60% quantile and with a variance above the 80% quantile to avoid overly general search terms with a constantly high search volume and search terms with high volatility, as either provide little information about salience trends. Note that the resulting variable is not comparable between issues because the data are based on the relative popularity within search terms over time. We account for this in the analysis by using a model with unit fixed effects. We discuss the validation of our measure against survey measures for salience in the [Online Appendix D.1](#).

[Online Appendix Figure E.18](#) illustrates the main variables for the Environment and the German Green party (monthly).

Modelling

The dependent variables of our models are the monthly party-specific salience measures for the different issue areas. Our modelling strategy focuses on creating a valid representation of the issue attention in the different areas and involves the use of fixed effects OLS panel estimators. Timing window and temporal aggregation. A natural question is how quickly parties adjust after polling shocks. For MPs' social media, Pedersen and Seeberg (2025) leverage a short pre/post window (two weeks before vs. two weeks after each monthly poll) and detect increased alignment with media issues after negative polls. Our cross-national party design prioritises comparability across countries and issues, for which press releases, polling summaries, and search-based salience are most consistently available at the monthly cadence. We therefore estimate month-to-month within-party changes as our main window and report a weekly sensitivity analysis in the [Online Appendix](#), which yields substantively similar conclusions. To address concerns about potential autoregression, we also present models including lagged dependent variables in [Online Appendix H](#), where we work with two lags of the dependent variable (dynamic models). This means that these models assume a serial correlation structure, where the first-order and second-order lags of the dependent variable are correlated with the dependent variable, but there should be no higher-order serial correlation.

The independent variables are included as exogenous variables in the dynamic panel model. We compute each party's month-to-month change in polling support and create a within-party indicator for substantial losses by flagging months that fall into the party-specific bottom 33rd percentile of its own change distribution. This normalisation anchors the loss definition to a party's typical size and volatility rather than a common absolute threshold. In practice, the 33rd-percentile cut-off corresponds on average to roughly a 2.9 percentage point decline relative to a party's last-election vote share across parties. For robustness, we also test a range of alternative specifications in [Online Appendix F](#).

In order to evaluate the different hypotheses, we interact these variables in three subsequent model specifications with the measures of hypothesis: issue ownership, public salience of the topic and the issue raised by the most successful party in the polls. According to the hypotheses, we would expect that the interaction with the *Poll loser* variable is positive, as losing support in the polls should lead parties to increase the issue attention to the area that they either own (Hypothesis 1), that has high public salience (Hypothesis 2), or that is raised by a successful competitor (Hypothesis 3). We do not make any predictions about the interactions with the *Poll winner* variable.

Operationalisation for Hypothesis 4 (large/persistent losses). Consistent with the [Online Appendix](#), we implement three variants that capture stronger polling shocks: (i) Persistent 3 mo – indicator equals 1 only when there are consecutive gains or losses over a three-month period; (ii) Contextual – indicator equals 1 for losses below the 33rd percentile (or gains above the 66th percentile) when polling levels are below (above) the twelve-month mean, respectively; and (iii) Contextual Large – same as Contextual but restricted to more extreme changes, i.e., losses below the 10th percentile and gains above the 90th percentile. These specifications are estimated with the same two-way fixed-effects structure as the main models; combined marginal effects are reported in [Online Appendix Figure G.21](#).

Operationalisation for Hypothesis 5 (electoral cycle). We re-estimate the main models restricting the sample to the last six months before an election, using national parliamentary election calendars to define the window. Model structure and covariates are kept identical to the baseline; combined marginal effects are shown in [Online Appendix Figure G.22](#).

Results

We test our hypotheses in separate regressions. [Figure 1](#) presents the results for three models and illustrates the main marginal effects (full results in [Table 1](#)). Evaluating the different hypotheses, we find little support that strong changes in polls lead to issue attention changes. Of our main independent variables, none of the specified interactions between

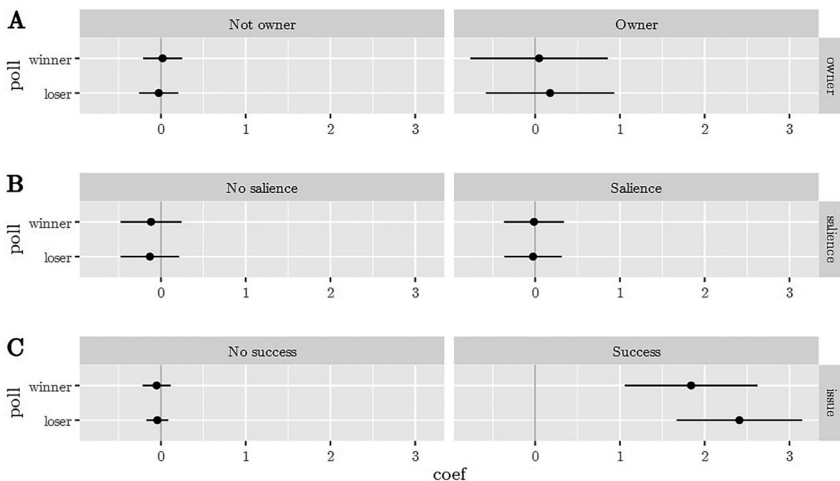


Figure 1. Combined marginal effects from fixed-effects OLS estimation.

Note: The dependent variable is the predicted change in issue attention in the $t + 1$.

Table 1. Results from fixed-effects OLS estimation.

Dependent variable:	Party attention to issue		
	Owner (1)	Salience (2)	Issue (3)
<i>Model:</i>			
<i>Variables</i>			
Poll loser	−0.0259 (0.1178)	−0.1300 (0.1760)	−0.0427 (0.0657)
Poll winner	0.0198 (0.1171)	−0.1166 (0.1833)	−0.0507 (0.0841)
Owner × Poll loser	0.2021 (0.4014)		
Owner × Poll winner	0.0269 (0.4310)		
Public salience		0.0996*** (0.0072)	
Public salience × Poll loser		0.0050 (0.0061)	
Public salience × Poll winner		0.0034 (0.0064)	
Successful issue			1.945*** (0.3123)
Successful issue × Poll loser			0.5073 (0.4262)
Successful issue × Poll winner			−0.0546 (0.4804)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>			
panelid	Yes	Yes	Yes
month_t	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	28,171	79,493	52,770
R^2	0.17945	0.26853	0.28387
Within R^2	1.64×10^{-5}	0.00936	0.00465

Clustered (panelid) standard-errors in parentheses.

Signif. Codes: ***0.001; **0.01; *0.05.

the *Poll loser* variable and the variables for issue ownership, salience, and emphasis by a successful competitor are significant at conventional levels, but they are in the expected direction and are larger than for the interactions with *Poll winner*. The combined marginal effects plotted in 1 reflect these results. Note that we only find combined effects of statistical significance for parties taking up the issue of a successful competitor. However, this is independent of whether a party lost in the polls or not. In sum, we take the results as evidence that our hypotheses about party competition over the electoral cycle do not explain parties' dynamic issue competition sufficiently. In the following section on 'Additional Analyses', we discuss under which circumstances parties may still respond according to our expectations.

Relation to recent evidence. Short-run responsiveness is often detected in more targeted settings: campaign statements in Portugal suggest rhetorical adjustment to pre-election poll signals (Pereira 2019); exposure to

internal public-opinion research causally shifts German cabinet speech on topics and positions within a two-week window (Hager and Hilbig 2020); and Danish MPs align social-media posts with contemporaneous top media issues after negative polls (Pedersen and Seeberg 2025). Our null findings likely reflect scope differences: we study centralised party press releases (not MPs' social media or leaders' speeches), across nine countries and throughout full electoral cycles. Organisational and coalition constraints between elections, the slower cadence of press-release workflows, and cross-national aggregation can dampen short-run adjustments that are more visible in single-country, elite-speech, or social-media contexts.

Large and persistent losses

Threshold models of information processing imply that parties react mainly to large and persistent losses, not to minor volatility. Yet, inconsistent with *Hypothesis 4*, when we redefine losses to capture large and persistent deteriorations in support, we do not find systematic evidence that losing parties pivot towards owned issues or highly salient ones. Moreover, when coefficients turn statistically significant, they also do so for poll gains, suggesting that parties' adjustments in issue emphasis are not uniquely tied to electoral losses. Instead, both gains and losses sometimes coincide with changes in communication, suggesting a more complex or less directional relationship between performance signals and party strategy.

Electoral cycle

Previous research about party responsiveness over the electoral cycle suggests that parties' communication strategies follow different logics. Whereas parties need to demonstrate unity when they govern together, they engage differentiation when elections near (Lupia and Strom 1995; Sagarzazu and Klüver 2017). This might suggest that parties stress owned issues more and engage less in imitation in the time before elections. Yet, other evidence also finds parties to be more responsive to public salience during campaigns (Pereira 2019). We do not find evidence that the logics of issue attention are stronger at the end of the electoral cycle.

Control variables

We find our control variables to behave as expected. Whether a party lost in the polls applies equally to all issues under analysis, and is therefore not a predictor for the attention given to an issue. Public salience and being the main issue of a successful competitor, however, have a

significant and positive effect on the attention parties pay to the issue. We take this as tentative evidence that our models capture the dynamics of party competition.

Additional analyses

In order to account for these complexities of party competition, we further investigate several contextual factors that may influence whether parties respond to short-term changes in the polls. Previous studies have found that party responsiveness is conditioned by party type (Klüver and Spoon 2016), cabinet status (Klüver and Spoon 2017), issue (Spoon and Klüver 2015), and the electoral cycle (Lupia and Strom 1995; Sagarzazu and Klüver 2017). We find suggestive evidence of increased responsiveness for niche parties, more salient issues, and at the end of the electoral cycle. The analyses with figures and tables can be found in [Online Appendix G](#).

Party type

Previous research has found that niche parties are more responsive than mainstream parties in their owned issue areas (Klüver and Spoon 2016). In line with Klüver and Spoon (2016), we find that niche parties emphasise their owned issues when they go down in the polls, whereas mainstream parties show no response. For the hypotheses about salience as well as about the issue of the successful competitor, we find no differences compared to the main models.

Cabinet status

Government parties often face greater constraints in setting their issue agendas compared to opposition parties (Klüver and Spoon 2016). As they are responsible for governing, they must navigate the complexities of implementing policies and are held accountable for recent policy decisions. This limits their flexibility in quickly proposing new policies or addressing emerging issues. Furthermore, in the countries examined, coalition governments are the norm, which imposes additional limitations on individual coalition partners (Klüver and Spoon 2017). Despite these potential differences, our analysis of the government and opposition parties does not reveal a significant increase in responsiveness for either group.

Issues

The responsiveness of the parties also depends on the issue and its context. Spoon and Klüver (2015) find that parties are more responsive on

issues where the public is divided and stay silent on less contentious issues. We therefore rerun our main models only for the issues of Environment and Immigration, two arguably salient issues. The interaction terms are again largely insignificant, yet with some differences between the issues. There is some indication that immigration, but not environment, is emphasised by issue owners when they lose in the polls. Environment, however, tends to be de-emphasised when it is the issue of the most successful party and a party loses in the polls.

Conclusion

In this article, we investigated the responsiveness of political parties throughout the entire electoral cycle. Using the PARTYPRESS database, we constructed a dynamic measure of party issue attention and tested three hypotheses concerning how parties adjust their focus over time. Our analysis covered the issue agendas of 68 parties in nine countries over a ten-year period, utilising more than 250,000 press releases. By examining the relationship between public opinion polls and parties' issue agendas, we sought to illuminate the dynamics of party responsiveness.

Our findings offer limited support for the hypothesis that declining poll performance leads parties to shift their issue focus. While we observed a general influence of public salience on parties' agendas, parties did not appear to significantly alter their priorities in response to losing poll support. Specifically, when parties lose ground in the polls, they do not consistently prioritise their owned issues, nor do they increase attention to popular issues or adopt the issue focus of more successful competitors. Although our analysis confirms that parties are broadly responsive to public opinion, this responsiveness seems to operate independently of short-term electoral fortunes. Our comprehensive analysis suggests that parties do not react to electoral signals in a manner predicted by existing theories. This contrasts with previous research, which demonstrates heightened responsiveness during election campaigns (Pereira 2019, 2020), and to studies showing that politicians systematically consider public opinion polls when making policy decisions (Hager and Hilbig 2020; Jacobs and Shapiro 1995; Pickup and Hobolt 2015).

Our results indicate that the current hypotheses are insufficient to fully explain how political parties respond to public opinion polls. Parties do not adjust their attention to the key issues of successful challengers (Böhmelt *et al.* 2016; DiMaggio and Powell 1983), nor do they consistently focus on publicly salient issues (Ansolabehere and Iyengar 1994), or prioritise their core issues (Petrocik 1996) when faced with significant losses in the polls. One possible explanation for these null findings is theoretical: The three perspectives presented may not adequately capture the mechanisms through which parties adapt their issue agendas in

response to changing public support. Future research should develop additional hypotheses to better understand how parties navigate issue competition in multiparty systems.

Evidence from more targeted contexts documents short-run responsiveness – campaign statements, executive speech, and MPs’ social media—(Hager and Hilbig 2020; Pedersen and Seeberg 2025; Pereira 2019), while other work reports more limited responsiveness over longer periods (Dassonneville *et al.* 2025). Others demonstrate that both voter attention and elite effort concentrate in campaign periods, which conditions observed responsiveness (Abney *et al.* 2013; Andersen *et al.* 2005; Gelman and King 1993). Read together with our findings, this points to context- and channel-dependence in elite reactions to public signals.

These patterns carry implications for representation. A mismatch between party agendas and citizen priorities can depress participation and satisfaction with democracy (Reher 2014, 2015). Normatively, this temporal clustering of alignment into campaign windows risks underweighting policy signals between elections, suggesting value in strengthening between-election feedback channels and lowering organisational adjustment costs in centralised party communication.

Notes

1. We lack issue ownership data for Poland and Spain, and the issue categories Technology and Foreign Trade.
2. Additionally, we do not have ownership data for all country-issue combinations covered by the PARTYPRESS Database.

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